



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 11.1: FLUID MOVEMENT BETWEEN SCALE PATTERNS

MASTERING SCALE TRANSITIONS FROM A ROOT NOTE

INTRODUCTION

One of the most powerful skills a guitarist can develop is the ability to **seamlessly transition between different scales from the same root note**. This allows for greater **melodic diversity, expressive soloing, and creative improvisation**.

In this lesson, we'll explore:

- ✓ **The key differences between common scales built from the root A**
- ✓ **How to visualise these scales across the fretboard**
- ✓ **Techniques for transitioning smoothly between them**
- ✓ **Practical exercises to incorporate them into your playing**

By the end of this lesson, you'll be able to **fluidly shift between pentatonic, modal, and full diatonic scales**, expanding your soloing vocabulary dramatically.

1. UNDERSTANDING SCALE DIFFERENCES: A ROOT-BASED APPROACH

Let's start by comparing the **five most used scales from the root note A**:

SCALE NAME	NOTES	INTERVAL FORMULA	Sound Character
A Minor Pentatonic	A-C-D-E-G	1, b3, 4, 5, 7	Bluesy, rock-based
A Major Pentatonic	A-B-C#-E-F#	1, 2, 3, 5, 6,	Country, melodic
A Natural Minor (Aeolian)	A-B-C-D-E-F-G	1, 2, b3, 4, 5, b6, b7	Dark, sad
A Dorian Mode	A-B-C-D-E-F#-G	1, 2, b3, 4, 5, 6, b7	Funky, jazzy
A Major Scale (Ionian)	A-B-C#-D-E-F#-G#	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7	Bright, melodic

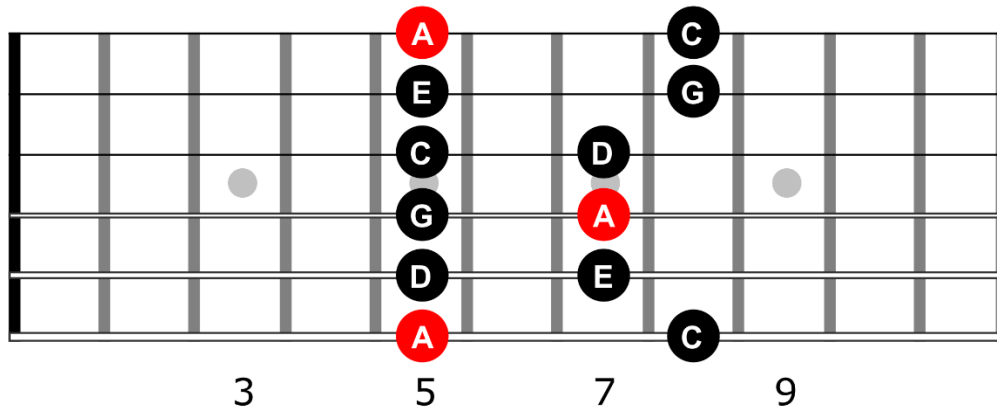
Key Insight:

- **The pentatonic scales are simpler 5-note versions of full 7-note scales.**
- **The difference between modes is often just 1-2 notes, but that dramatically affects the feel of your playing.**



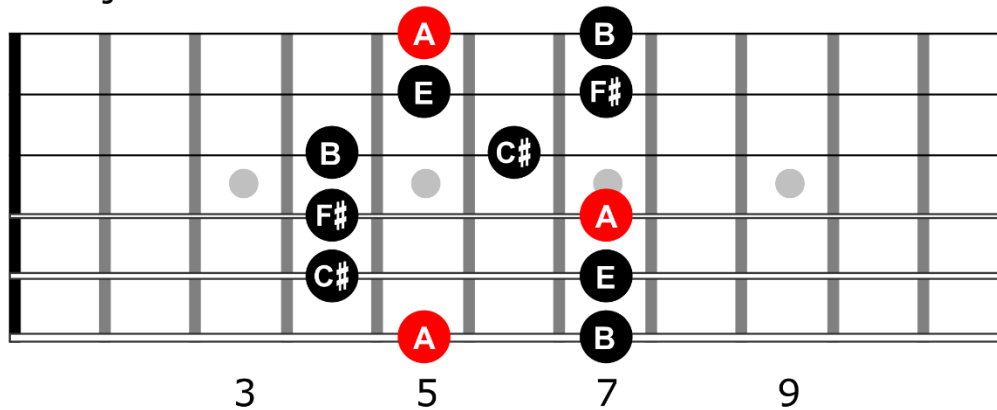
Now, let's **visualise these scales** in the **same position (5th fret area)** so we can learn to transition between them.

A Minor Pentatonic - Box 1



✔ Commonly used for blues, rock, and classic solos.

A Major Pentatonic



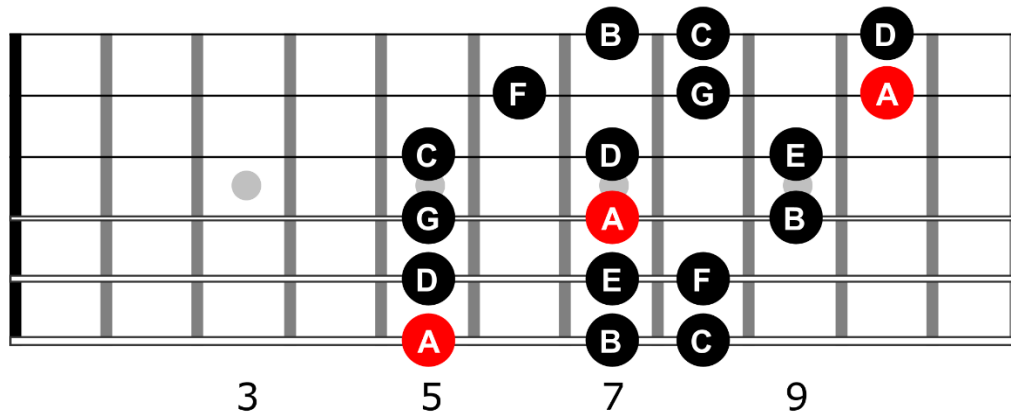
✔ *Bright and melodic, often used in country, rock, and major-key improvisation.*



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A NATURAL MINOR (AEOLIAN MODE)

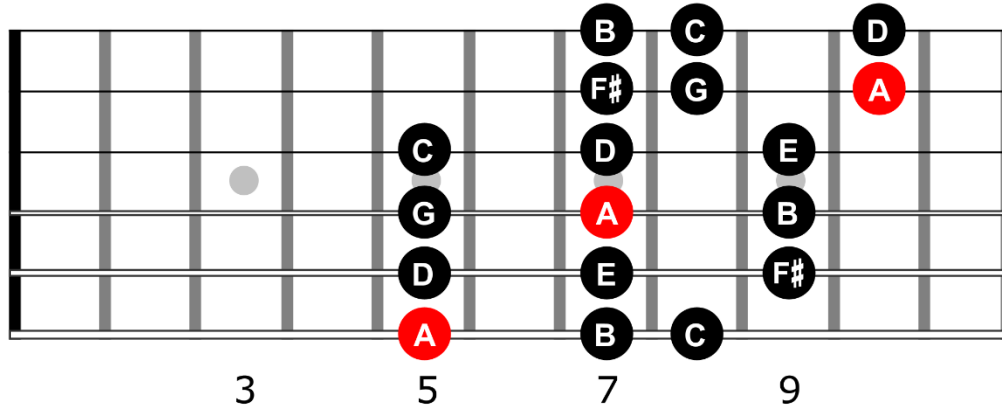
A Aeolian



✓ Full minor scale sound, perfect for expressive, moody playing.

A DORIAN MODE (SAME ROOT, DIFFERENT FEEL)

A Dorian



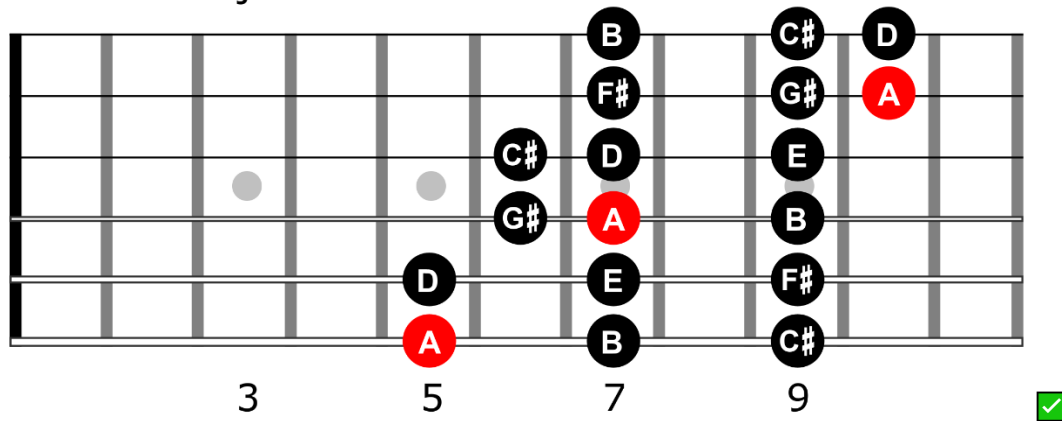
✓ Adds the major 6th (F#), giving a more jazzy, funky sound.



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A MAJOR SCALE (IONIAN MODE)

A Ionian Major



Foundation for all major-key melodies and improvisation.

3. HOW TO TRANSITION SMOOTHLY BETWEEN THESE SCALES

The key to **fluid movement between scales** is recognising **shared notes** and using **sliding, legato, and phrasing techniques** to connect them naturally.

STEP 1: FIND COMMON NOTES BETWEEN SCALES

Here are some **common connections** you can use:

- **A Minor Pentatonic & A Natural Minor** → Identical except for **B** and **F natural**
- **A Minor Pentatonic & A Dorian** → Just add **F# (6th)** and **B (2nd)**
- **A Major Pentatonic & A Major Scale** → Just add **D (4th)** and **G# (7th)**



Example Transition:

1. Start with an **A Minor Pentatonic** lick
2. Add **B (2nd)** and **F# (6th)** to shift into Dorian
3. Or slide into **C#** and **G#** to transition into A Major

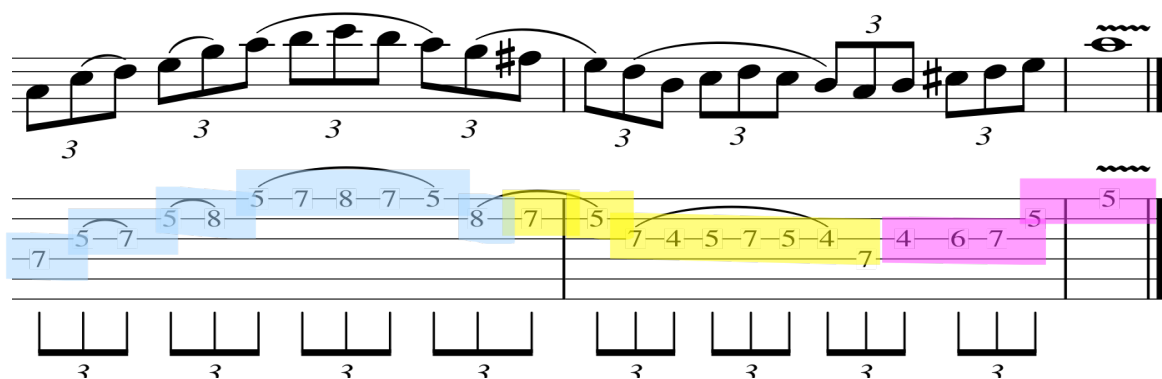


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STEP 1: CREATE YOUR OWN HYBRID PHRASES

Here's an **exercise to transition smoothly from Minor Pentatonic to Dorian and then to Ionian Major**:

- ✓ Start **A Minor Pentatonic** (bluesy)
- ✓ Add **A Dorian notes** (jazzy)
- ✓ End on **A Major scale notes** (major lift)



- ✓ Starts **pentatonic**, shifts to **Dorian** via **F# (7th fret B string)**, then ascends in **A Ionian Major**.

Record yourself switching scales and listen back!

STEP 2. APPLY THIS TO A BACKING TRACK

To really lock this in, **practice over an A Minor or A Major backing track**.

- **Blues track?** Stay in **A Minor Pentatonic** but introduce **A Dorian** for spice.
- **Major ballad?** Start with **A Major Pentatonic**, then expand into **A Major Scale**.
- **Funky jam?** Use **A Dorian** to get that Santana-style vibe.

- ✓ Experiment with **which scale changes feel best to you!**
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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✓ All scales share common tones—use those to transition smoothly
 - ✓ Using sliding, legato, and phrasing makes transitions feel natural
 - ✓ Pentatonic scales are simplified versions of full modes—expand them
 - ✓ Switch scales based on the backing track's mood and harmonic context
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Lesson Wrap-Up

Now that you can **move fluidly between different scales from A**, experiment with applying this to **solos, riffs, and improvisation**.

Your Challenge:

1. Improvise a **solo that starts in A Minor Pentatonic and moves into Dorian**
2. Try a **lick that starts in A Major and resolves into A Minor Pentatonic**
3. **Record yourself** and listen for **fluidity and expression**



Next Lesson: Expanding scale transitions into **chord tone targeting** for stronger phrasing!

Peace, Rob Lobasso   